

Working within the front-of-house/ back-of-house boundary: Room attendants in the hotel guest room space

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ABSTRACT

Context is an important but largely ignored dimension of quality service encounters. This paper contributes to the hospitality service industries literature by examining how the front-of-house and back-of-house boundary work (Nippert-Eng 1996, 2003) engaged by Room Attendants working within the hotel guest room space impact on the hospitality impression management performed. Qualitative data from fieldwork engaging with hotel employees located within the tourist resort of Queenstown New Zealand are used to explore the multiple fronts on which the front-of-house and back-of-house boundaries are simultaneously negotiated. The results suggest that Room Attendants negotiate the front-of-house and back-of-house boundary through objects – such as the guest room and articles belonging to the guest – and aspects of self – such as impression management, safety, socialising and self-responsibility for room checking. The results support the importance of considering context when seeking to understand the complexities associated with the (re)production of a reliably positive service encounter.

Keywords: hotels; service encounter; dramaturgical; front-of-house; back-of-house; boundaries

INTRODUCTION

It was the end of the day – 4:30 – she was tired. We should have been finished but we were late due to illness. She said, “Can I do your room” and the guest said, “Can you come back in half an hour?” She said, “No, we’ll be gone by then because we’ll have finished”. And he said, “Well I was out all day and I’ve just got back” and she said, “That’s not my problem I have to do the whole hotel.” I think it was the way he picked it up but we got a letter from him to the General Manager (House-keeping Manager Dale).

The service encounter is at the heart of the service product (Chapman & Lovell 2006). As this interaction between a hotel guest and room attendant suggests however, not all service encounters are positive and productive. A key problem for the service industries therefore, is how to ensure that the service encounter is both high quality and reliable (Nath & Raheja 2001). Quality service is conventionally defined as ‘the gap between consumers’ expectations about a service and their subsequent perception of service performance’ (Gould-Williams 1999: 101). The SERVQUAL instrument developed by Parasura-

man, Zeithaml and Berry (1988, 1991) has been used extensively by researchers to understand the perception consumers have of the 'reliability, empathy, assurance, responsiveness and tangibles' of their service encounters (Gould-Williams, 1999: 100). In terms of the production side of the service encounter, considerable attention has been given to the relationship between front-line service employees and customer satisfaction (Hartline, Wooldridge & Jones 2003; Kang, Okamoto & Donovan 2004; Lee & Hu 2004; Luchars & Hinkin 1996). Accordingly, service employee characteristics (Forseth 2005; Iacobucci & Ostrom 1993; Moshavi 2004; Ryoo 2005) and behaviour (Karatepe & Sokmen 2006; Karatepe, Uludag, Menevis, Hadzimehmedagic & Baddar 2006; Vieira 2005) have been studied in an effort to understand how a high quality service interaction can be reliably (re)produced. This emphasis on front-line employees and their individual traits however, tends to ignore the importance of context. The focus in this paper will be on service encounters between non front-line housekeeping employees and the hotel guest. As a result of the mix between cleaning and guest interaction – as shown in the quote above – an understanding of quality service encounters between housekeeping staff and hotel guests is impossible without attending to context.

One stream of service research that does consider context is the Goffman (1959) informed dramaturgical approach to the service encounter. With service delivery being very much about performance, attention is drawn to the designated areas where a performance is given and those where the performance is not necessary. In hotels this performance space is labelled front-of-house (FOH) while the back-of-house (BOH) is where the service employee may relax his/her impression performance. In these studies however, the demarcation between performance space and non-performance space is assumed to be clear. Drawing from the work on organisational boundaries presented by Nippert-Eng (1996, 2003) the research presented in this paper con-

tributes to the service management literature by examining service encounter performances in the FOH/BOH boundary region. More specifically, I will explore the multiple fronts along which housekeeping employees negotiate the FOH/BOH boundary within the ambiguous space of the hotel guest room. In so doing, the importance of this boundary work to the quality service encounter will be identified. The empirical material presented in this paper is drawn from a study of hotel employees within the tourist resort of Queenstown New Zealand.

THEORETICAL BACKGROUND

At the heart of service production is the service encounter (Gould-Williams 1999). The service encounter is defined as 'the time frame during which a customer directly interacts with service providers' (Den Harting & Mattsson 1999: 28). Gutek, Cherry, Bhappu, Schneider and Woolf (2000) distinguish between service relationships and service encounters. If the customer and service provider are able to identify each other as individuals, if they have a history of interacting with each other and an expectation of interaction in the future, then this is known as a relationship. The service encounter on the other hand, is a one-time interaction between strangers with no expectation that they will interact with each other in the future (Gutek et al. 2000). The service encounter therefore, is a very particular sort of social interaction. While it brings together two strangers – one in need of a service (Namasi-vayam & Hinkin 2003) and one charged with delivering that service in an effective but efficient way (Forseth 2005) – there are clear expectations as to the outcome of this interaction. Quite simply, it is expected that the customer will come out of the interaction satisfied. Customer satisfaction is a commercial imperative for the service organisation because of the positive correlation it has with future attitudes, intentions and behaviour of the customer (Dawes & Rowley 1996; Mattila 2000; Severt, Tesome & Murrman 2005). One of the enduring difficulties for hospitality managers

however, is the intangible and unpredictable nature of the service encounter (Crang 1994). In the hotel setting there is the added complexity of a broad temporal and spatial spread to the operation. Thus, as Namasivayam and Hinkin (2003: 26) acknowledge 'the communication and behaviours that occur in the service encounter are effectively beyond the manager's control and at the discretion of the employee. In an attempt to give form to this fluid and amorphous production process, service management researchers engage a dramaturgical metaphor (Clark & Salaman 1998; Crang 1994; Dillard, Browning, Sitkin & Sutcliffe 2000; Grove, Fisk & Dorsch 1998; Weaver 2005). In so doing, the service encounter is translated into a 'performance' or 'display' by the service employee for the customer audience (Crang 1994; Forseth 2005).

Writers using a dramaturgical approach invariably draw on Erving Goffman's 1959 book *The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life* (Bunzel, Clegg & Teal 2002; Clark & Salaman 1998; Crang 1994; Dillard et al. 2000; Grove et al. 1998). As Weaver (2005: 8) puts it, in viewing social interaction through a theatrical lens, Goffman sees that individuals 'play particular roles when they interact with certain audiences (co-workers, customers, friends, and family members)'. Performance in the Goffman (1959) sense involves two different kinds of communication activity. First, the expression an actor 'gives' is related to the conscious and careful communication of information. Secondly, the actor also 'gives off' unconscious signs and cues (Doorne & Ateljevic 2005). In assuming that social performances are engaged for a particular reason, Goffman (1959: 4) suggests that through these two expressive activities actors 'will convey an impression to others which it is in his interests to convey'. In this sense, any act of communication becomes a performance involving impression management. In order to manage the impression an actor makes to a specific audience an effort is made to control the signs and cues the actor both gives and gives off to that audience (Doorne & Ateljevic 2005).

In this sense, the (re)production of a high quality service encounter – one which leaves the customer satisfied – is managed through the careful 'scripting' of the service impression (Chapman & Lovell 2006; Dillard et al. 2000).

Unlike conventional theatre the service audience is actively engaged in the service performance. In other words, they do not sit back passively gazing upon a spectacle. Rather, they are drawn into the service performance through their interaction with the service employee. As Crang (1994: 696) notes however, the service encounter is 'marked by the co-presence of production and a particular form of consumption'. Thus, while participating in the production of the service performance, these service customers are simultaneously assessing the quality of the service they are consuming (Parasuraman et al. 1988, 1991). Interestingly, service interactions are known as 'moments of truth' for an organisation (Mahesh 1993). The truth of this moment however, lies not in the authenticity of the social interaction but the quality of the performance. In other words, this is not an authentic host-guest relationship but the managed impression of genuine 'kindness in welcoming' this stranger or guest (Makins 1991: 751). As Wood (1994: 71) notes, in offering the public a service in return for payment, 'guests' expectations are that service will be rendered to them as private individuals. The problem for the hotel is to provide such service while disguising the fact that the provision is, for the hotel, a generalized business function rendered not to individuals but to sets of them'. What is being disguised is the in-authenticity of this personalised host-guest interaction. A poorly managed impression therefore, not only produces an unconvincing performance it also reveals the inauthentic and performed nature of the social interaction with the customer. As such, 'conduct of any performance is...characterised by a considerable degree of risk, danger, uncertainty. Should the veil drop and the 'back-stage' be revealed to the audience, the performer is exposed with the consequence that the audience may

reconceptualise the role of the performer' (Clark & Salaman 1998: 27). A key strategy engaged by hotels to minimise the possibility of a 'dropped veil' revealing the service encounter for what it is – a commercially driven performance – is the management of hotel service space.

The management of service space

As Hernes (2004: xvii-xviii) suggests, 'any act of organizing is about creating a space for human action and interaction'. Like any conventional theatre setting, service space is categorized as front-stage or back-stage depending on the presence or absence of the audience (Goffman 1959). In the hotel context this front/back-stage language is translated into front-of-house (FOH) and back-of-house (BOH). As hotel guests are located within the FOH space this is where the hospitality impression is performed. In the BOH space the service customer is excluded and therefore the employee-performer is permitted to drop their service impression act (Goffman 1959; Wood 1994). I do acknowledge that there are other impressions the employee will be conveying even in the BOH regions. The presence of a manager and work peers for example, point to the multiplicity of impressions individual employees will perform during their everyday work experience. Cues to whether the space is front or back are usually provided by the hotel architecture and decor. For example the hotel reception area is generally the most expensively decorated and the desk itself delineates the boundary between FOH guest-space and the BOH employee space. The key point for this discussion is that these clearly separated regions control both employees and customers by providing a clear marker of where the service encounter should occur and where it shouldn't (Doorne & Ateljevic 2005; Wood 1994). In other words, the danger of revealing the back-stage to a hotel customer – and thus dispelling the impression of authentic hospitality – is reduced by demarking a front and back stage space. Implicit in this organisation of FOH/BOH space is the creation and

maintenance of physical, cultural and social boundaries (Doorne & Ateljevic 2005; Wood 1994).

Where the definition of the space is unambiguous and the boundary between FOH and BOH clear – taking the form of a physical object such as a desk for example – the risk of exposing in-authenticity is minimal. Not all spaces within the hotel however, have clear FOH/BOH boundaries. Guest rooms for example, 'are public (front) areas only at certain times. They are usually cleaned in the morning after guests have left and before they return or new guests arrive. During that time, guestrooms become quasi-private (back) areas where guests are not particularly welcomed' (Bunzel et al. 2002: 7). Unlike the reception area, the restaurant, the kitchen and the laundry for example, the architecture, décor and inclusion/exclusion of the guest does not provide a cue about the front or back status of the guest room space. Instead, it is imprecise cues such as the time of day, the official occupancy of the room, and the presence/absence of the guest that define this space. The guest room therefore, represents an interesting and important boundary region where service employees must effect the important transition between FOH performance and BOH non-performance using unstructured social and temporal cues. The question that emerges from this literature therefore, is how do – the non front-line – housekeeping service employees working within the guest room space manage the important FOH/BOH boundary?

A number of writers have explored organisation of work at the boundaries (Fleming & Spicer 2004; Fournier 2000; Hernes 2004; Nippert-Eng 1996, 2003; Paulsen & Hernes 2003; Perlow 1998). It is Nippert-Eng's (1996, 2003) study of 'boundary work' between the work and home realms however, that provides the most useful platform for exploring how FOH/BOH boundaries are established in the ambiguous space of the hotel guest room. For Nippert-Eng (1996, 2003) boundary work is 'the strategies, principles, and practices we use to create, maintain, and

modify cultural categories' such as home and work (Nippert-Eng 1996: 7). It is through boundary work that we transform relatively undifferentiated space – such as the hotel guest room – into relatively distinct 'artificial, socially embedded' territories (Nippert-Eng 1996: 10) – such as FOH and BOH regions. Two key dynamics are involved with boundary work: the first defines the two separate realms and the second maintains this separation by 'allowing us to jump back and forth over it' (Nippert-Eng 2003: 268). The clarity and conceptual solidity of the boundary varies according to the degree of segmentation or integration between the people, objects and ideas of the separate realms (Nippert-Eng 1996, 2003). Inviting work colleagues home for a barbeque for example, shows a level of integration between the people of the work and home realms. In theorising organisational boundaries in terms of the boundary work engaged by employees, Nippert-Eng's (1996, 2003) writing highlights the complexity that many service industry employees navigate in their daily work tasks. As Nippert-Eng (2003: 268) suggests, 'boundary work is first and foremost a mental activity, but it must be enacted and enhanced through a largely visible collection of essential, practical activities'. Hence, 'there are multiple, equally important fronts along which...(organisation boundaries)...must be simultaneously negotiated' (Nippert-Eng 1996: 8). Thus, my specific research questions for this paper are:

- What are the dimensions through which hotel room attendants draw a boundary between the FOH and BOH service realms within the guest room space?
- How does this boundary work contribute to hospitality impression management within the hotel?

METHOD

Site and Participants

The data drawn upon in this paper comes from a larger body of fieldwork collected from seven

accommodation hotels in the tourist resort of Queenstown New Zealand. These hotels range in size from 275 to 138 rooms. My initial research interest focused on the nature of the hotel's human resource management (HRM) concerns. I collected data from 27 senior managers and 40 operational employees of these hotels. What I found particularly interesting when listening, reading and reflecting upon the accounts provided by the managers and the operational staff was the complex relationship between space and the service performance. This was particularly obvious in the accounts provided by employees within the Housekeeping Department.

Procedure

I gained entry into the field through a snowball method. Given the exploratory nature of the research agenda, the semi-structured interview was selected as the most appropriate method for collecting data. The interviews began with open-ended questions concerning the participants' motivation for and experience of working at these Queenstown hotels. Following this, the interview questions sought to explore what these individuals felt were the positive and negative features of their current work experience. The interviews with the managers were extended by questions relating to their particular HRM related operational issues.

Analysis

The 67 transcribed interviews were read initially to select out those who worked within the Housekeeping Department. Of the 67 hotel employees I interviewed, 10 were involved in housekeeping. Four were in management positions, five attended rooms and one ran the laundry. The 10 transcripts that were selected were read again more closely to gain a sense of the multiple facets of the RAs' work activities – the cleaning activities and also interactions with guests and fellow housekeeping staff. Using Nippert-Eng's (1996: 8) notion that 'there are multiple, equally important fronts along which...(organisation boundaries)...must be simultane-

ously negotiated' these 10 transcripts were then manually coded and units of data illustrating the dimensions through which the housekeeping employees articulated a differentiation between FOH service encounter activities and BOH non-service encounter/support activities.

RESULTS

Housekeeping as an ambiguous BOH support/FOH performance space

Within the hotel the housekeeping department is considered a BOH operation and is primarily engaged in the cleaning of bedrooms and suites. Accordingly, Rawstron (1999: 114-115) describes the housekeeping department as support to the hotel business as a whole however, 'the majority of this work and effort occur out of sight and mind of the customer'. As Rooms Division Manager Bess illustrates however, there are times when housekeeping staff are visible to the hotel guest. Due to the intermittent and marginal role of interaction with guests in the Room Attendant's (RA) work, demands for a FOH performance is down-played through reference to the high-profile FOH receptionist role:

With regard to housekeeping you have staff who are spread from one end of the building to the other, who may have an entire floor to clean by themselves. And though they do have guest contact it's not as direct as the front office get. A receptionist will generally have a guest right there, two steps away from them all the time. Whereas a housemaid may go to clean a room and the guests may still be there and they say "ok, fine come in we are just about to leave". And that is maybe all that will happen. So the guest contact is very different.

This quote by Bess speaks directly to the ambiguity that defines the housekeeping space. On one hand the RAs are likely to spend most of their work time unseen by both guests and fellow RAs. On the other hand they may come across guests – in their room or in the corridor – without

warning. Unlike front-line staff – such as the front office receptionist – who have guests 'two steps away from them all the time', the RAs are not likely to be in the service performance role when they encounter a guest. In other words, the space itself does not provide the service performance/non-performance cues. Rather it is the – often sudden and unexpected – presence/absence of the guest that must trigger the switch into service impression management mode (Goffman 1959).

While social interaction with the hotel guest is not the core of the RA's work role, they are still aware that they must convey the right impression – that is the commercially productive hospitality impression. Housekeeping Manager Annabel for example, actively encourages her RAs to work on their hospitality service performance:

The room attendants have contact with the guests from time to time...for example the Australian tourists have a rest day here so they are around a lot. That means they might do their room while they are here and they ask questions — "Where shall we go"? What shall we do"? I encourage them to give a bit of information themselves, use their own personality and answer questions themselves, use their initiative.

Some of the RAs take up the opportunity to engage with the guests. From RA Betty for example:

If you chat when they come in and go they might leave a good comment about how good you are. Maybe leave a tip. If I see \$1 or \$2 I start to feel that it might be a good day. If there are no tips by the 10th room I feel a little flat.

While tipping is not common within New Zealand's hospitality culture, for low status and low paid hospitality workers – such as housekeeping staff – it represents an important source of supplementary income (Weaver 2005). This quote from Betty however, also speaks to the visibility associated with the service encounter and the relative invisibility of the cleaning function.

The suggestion here is that if Betty chats the guests will be more satisfied with this service performance and hence will go to the trouble of filling out the guest feedback form. In cleaning without the social interaction however, Betty's service work is invisible to the guest. Put into the context of the theatre, the quality of the experience is attributed to the performance of the actors rather than the designers, builders and cleaners of the stage.

This lack of visibility given to BOH support, such as the housekeeping function – in relation to the high profile of the front-line functions – can be seen in the awareness these employees have of their low social status within the hotel operation. RA Doris for example, describes the usual reaction to her cleaning work:

A lot of people just look at you and say “eeuw yuck you go and clean other people's toilets”.

Housekeeping manager Annabel is acutely aware of this low status and works hard to build the morale of her staff by emphasising the necessity of the support they provide to the hotel's centre stage – the front office:

I tell them “...You are one of *the* most important components of the hotel and if you weren't here there wouldn't be any clean rooms. Those people out the front wouldn't have any rooms to sell.”

Interestingly, this statement by Annabel is clearly supported by Lockyer's (2005) research that high-lights the critical importance assigned to cleanliness of hotel facilities in a guests decision to stay at a hotel. An additional irony is that these RAs invariably have a more intimate knowledge of the guests than the higher status FOH employees. As the guest room is a BOH area for the guest as well as the hotel operation (Bunzel et al. 2002), it represents a space where the guest is also able to drop the curtain on his/her impression management performance. Accordingly, RA Betty notes:

In the privacy of their room, people are more talkative.

Along with the talkativeness however, is the way that the guest leaves the room. RA Doris comments about the state of the rooms she has to face:

Some of them have been, you know, they are disgusting. I don't know how they could sort of walk out a room and leave it like that.

Also from Housekeeping Manager Fran:

In those times of the year – Christmas and the ski season – they are often messy. It is just amazing what they are like sometimes. I think they live like that.

It is this combination of low visibility, ambiguous FOH/BOH categorisation of space and intimate contact with guests that render the Housekeeping Department a very complex – as well as vital – operational function within the hotel. The focus of this paper is on the way the ambiguity surrounding the categorisation of the guest room as FOH or BOH space – and the service performance demands that are associated with that categorisation – are managed by the RAs. Nippert-Eng (1996) suggests that there are multiple dimensions through which organisational boundaries are negotiated. For the RAs of this study, the boundary between FOH service encounter and BOH service support are simultaneously negotiated through objects and aspects of their self.

The FOH/BOH boundary through objects

The guest room

A key mechanism the RAs use to differentiate space as FOH/BOH is through physical objects. The primary object is the guest room. The dominant meaning given by the RAs to the bedrooms is that of a vacated space. This sense of an empty 'theatre' was confirmed by room attendant Alison:

Most of the time when you go to do a room they aren't there or they ask you to come back later anyway.

In the absence of guests, the room is translated into a collection of surfaces to clean (Allen & Pryke, 1994). Charise for example, has a routine that pays particular attention to the bath:

I've been doing it for years so I've got my own routine...With me I've got this thing about hygiene and most people when they clean their bath they just spray it and then wipe it. But you get a lot of people that actually use it as a toilet. So with me I usually just run the water first just to wash it all out and then clean it.

In this vacated space it is the residue of the guest that has to be dealt with rather than the guest him/her self. From room attendant Alison:

It's worse in the ski season with all the snow boarders and everything like that coming in. Sometimes it's not too bad but with families who have children sometimes it sucks. But usually we take 34 minutes for a check-out and 20 minutes for a stay over. A lot of the time you can do it a lot quicker if they are really tidy.

As Alison suggests, the RAs categorize guest identity in terms of the amount and quality of the residue they leave in the room. In this way, the residue operates as a trace of the behind-the-scenes performance of the guests. The vacated room therefore is the consequence of a convincing hospitality performance where the guest has quite literally 'made themselves at home'. As Alison and Doris and Fran (above) note, some guests are 'at home' in greater mess than others. The residue thus represents an object boundary between a now extinct FOH service encounter and the BOH support operation whose job it is to erase its traces in preparation for the next guest.

Objects belonging to the guest

A similar but different dimension of the FOH/BOH boundary is drawn around the presence of objects belonging to the guest in the stay-over room. Stay-over rooms are where the guest is staying for more than one night. In this context

the shift from a FOH to a BOH space is much more tentative due to the presence of the guest's belongings. Room attendant Doris describes the way in which these belongings interrupt the clear lines of the room surfaces:

In a stay over you might be quicker. It might only take you five minutes...you just do what you have got to...you sort of walk all over their stuff...(laughter)...you have got no idea, yeah undies and stuff but you don't touch them, you're not allowed to touch any of their stuff so you just walk over their stuff.

As Housekeeping Manager Fran suggests treatment of these objects can have a significant impact on guest satisfaction with the hotel's service product and as such must be carefully avoided. For example, she instructs her RAs not to touch the toothbrush and water glass:

We had an incident where someone lost their contact lenses. The glass was by the bed and we tipped it down the sink.

In this way the objects of the guests render present the spectre of 'the guest' and so signify a FOH break within the otherwise BOH region.

While it is more usual for the stay-over guests to ask that the room attendants return later, sometimes they are invited to clean the room while the guest is present. This immediately transforms the room cleaning from a behind the scenes activity to one performed on the service stage. Room attendant Betty is acutely aware of the impairment to her technical competency as a result of inserting a service encounter into the cleaning routine. This technical competency is constructed in relation to the time it takes to clean the room:

If they say, "no, come in" while they are still there you know they want a chat. And so maybe it will take a long time to do that room.

Of course the presence of the RA also switches the guest room to a FOH space for the guest as well.

The FOH/BOH boundary through aspects of self

Service impression management

Nippert-Eng (2003: 268) notes that we present different aspects of our self, or different 'ways we think, act, and present ourselves in either realm'. In this, Nippert-Eng's (2003) aspects of self align compatibly with Goffman's (1959) notion of impression management. As noted above, the RAs were aware of the need for presenting themselves in a different way when interacting with hotel guests. For example, RA Alison knows that:

When you see guests you have to be nice. It's hard sometimes if you are in a bad mood. If that happens I just smile and say "Hi".

Housekeeping Manager Annabel actively encourages her girls to 'use their own personality and answer questions themselves, use their initiative'. This is similar to airline management's attempt to 'authentise' flight attendants' service encounter with airline passengers by encouraging them 'to think of passengers as if they were 'personal guest[s] in your living room' (1983: 105), with the hope that this would facilitate care in the air' (Hochschild (1983) cited by Crang 1994: 144). From a boundary perspective this encouragement to draw elements of authenticity into the service impression performance is also an active encouragement to integrate aspects of self across the FOH/BOH boundary region. While RA Betty has taken up this opportunity and has 'learnt how to talk to people and has become less shy', RA Charise is interesting for her active resistance of this integration.

I try to avoid (guests)...I'm scared they might ask me a question that I should know the answer to but I don't. They ask you how long you've been here and you tell them and they ask you "where's blah,blah,blah and I don't know.

Anxious of her ability to maintain the right impression, Charise avoids the guests when she

can and thus avoids moving across the FOH hospitality performance/BOH non-performance boundary.

Boundary lines can sometimes be seen most clearly through transgressions of that boundary. Through ineffective transition we can see the expectations of how that transition should be managed. The opening quote – in the introduction above – illustrates the vulnerability of the quality service encounter to the appropriate negotiation of the FOH/BOH boundary. The problem in this service encounter here is that the presence of the guest did not trigger an identification of and movement across the performance boundary. The presence of the guest always translates the room in question into a front region. As such, during this guest–employee interaction the employee should have given a front region performance. In this situation the employee engaged inappropriately in non-performance service impression behaviour. As Nippert-Eng (1996: 28) notes, 'time and space are shared and divided in the process of sculpting realism as we attempt to delineate and juxtapose these "territories" of the self'. Thus, I would argue that failing to recognise or construct a spatial and temporal boundary between her previous cleaning activities and her present encounter with the hotel guest, there was an insufficient delineation between the RA's BOH and FOH thinking, acting and presentation of self. In other words, the employee dropped the veil revealing the back-stage to the audience (Clark & Salaman 1998). As the letter of complaint signals, the outcome of this service encounter was a dissatisfied customer and a detrimental effect on the perception of service quality by the hotel guest.

Safety

The boundary between FOH and BOH service realms is also drawn in relation to RA safety. Again, this relates back to the ambiguity and complexity that surrounds the status of the guest room. The isolation and lack of visibility renders

the guest room a BOH space while it is being cleaned but also provides the privacy necessary for the guest to treat it as a BOH non-performance space. The threat to safety of the housekeeping staff comes from the isolation and lack of visibility in conjunction with the uncertainty that guests will also switch to a socially controlled FOH performance. From housekeeping manager Fran, for example:

They all work in pairs, its policy here. I tell them to keep the door open, so I know where they are... There haven't been any incidents but you do hear of them and you sometimes get undesirables. They may have the money to stay here but you don't trust them.

The day I spoke with room attendant Betty (from another hotel) she had been frightened by a guest. She describes the encounter thus:

They had gone to breakfast. The wife came back and I said, "All I need to do is vacuum." I had my back to the door and the husband came in and said, "Haven't you left yet?" I left and there were raised voices. That frightened me and I went into the next room until they had left.

What Betty witnessed was an argument between two hotel guests that was conducted in the 'privacy' of their BOH room space. Like most public witnesses to private disputes, Betty felt uncomfortable. Added to her discomfort however, was a sense of anxiety that comes from the location in which this encounter took place. In other words, unlike the reception area the room itself provides no boundaries between the stage and the off-stage. To retreat to a space that represented her off-stage therefore, Betty had to leave and go into another (vacated) room.

Socialising

An important dynamic that emerges from thinking about the FOH/BOH boundary making is the double stranded nature of the BOH. On the one hand is cleaning as opposed to social interac-

tion with the guest. The non-presence of guests however, also allow for social interaction with fellow workers. A work/non-work performance in other words, is made possible by the particular BOH conditions of room cleaning that renders it a largely invisible activity to guests and management alike. Within the guest room space therefore, the FOH/BOH boundary is drawn in terms of possibilities for social or non-work activities. RA Charise for example, describes the social chatting, jokes and TV watching engaged by some of her seasonal colleagues – in this case particularly males.

We had some English boys that were here. They livened us up with jokes... but with them being males they got away with a lot more stuff than we did... Some are good workers but the majority of them just fluff around. It's bad when its rugby season they just watch TV, and cricket too.

Here Charise introduces a gender aspect to the propensity of RAs to use the BOH status of the guest room to incorporate a switch from a public work presentation of self to a private one. While gender is not the particular focus of this paper this statement from Charise does suggest an interesting direction for further research. What for example, is the relationship between gender identification, location within particular occupations and the negotiation of work and non-work boundaries? A more advanced example of this switch – involving both male and female employees – was provided by a senior manager who referred to a situation where an employee was caught having sex – with another staff member – in one of the rooms during working hours.

As Namasivayam and Hinkin (2003: 26) note 'the communication and behaviours that occur in the service encounter are effectively beyond the manager's control and at the discretion of the employee'. What these accounts also emphasise is that much of the non-encounter housekeeping service support activities are also outside of management's supervisory eye. Management however,

are aware of these productivity issues. The primary mechanism they have for controlling the pace of cleaning work is through the allocation of time per room. Some have the RA's working on their own, while others have them working in pairs. As Housekeeping Manager Dale implies however, this pairing is careful and attempts to manage the work/non-work social boundary:

Some girls don't work with other people too well because they talk too much and don't get the work done. That is they stop what they are doing and talk.

Self-checking of rooms

The final front on which the FOH/BOH boundary is negotiated is the point at which the guest room is deemed to have switched from a non-available BOH space to a publicly available FOH space. Three of the Housekeeping Managers I spoke with talked about introducing a self-checking system. Conventionally it is the Housekeeping Supervisor or Manager who conducts a check of the cleaned vacated rooms and declares them available for a new set of hotel guests. With self checking however, it is the RA themselves who clean and check the room. The RAs were very aware of the new responsibility this room checking involved:

Self-checking is a lot more responsibility. We used to have supervisors coming behind us checking to make sure everything was right. And now the next people coming into a room after it is cleaned are the guests. So if there is anything wrong I'm the one that has to deal with it. It's heaps more responsibility (RA Alison).

From a boundary perspective, this new responsibility being given to the RAs can be understood as boundary management. As Nippert-Eng (2003: 268) suggests, 'boundary work is first and foremost a mental activity, but it must be enacted and enhanced through a largely visible collection of essential, practical activities'. The guest room is a physical space that is mentally divided into a

BOH or FOH region depending on the context. In terms of a newly vacated room, the primary role of the RA is to engage in a particular set of activities so that the categorisation of the guest room can switch from a BOH to a FOH space. To achieve the status of a FOH region, the surfaces within the guest room must look a particular way. The self-checking of the cleaned room thus represents the final step in the RA's practical activities that result in the re-categorisation of the guest room to a front-stage space.

DISCUSSION & CONCLUSION

Having explored the multiple fronts along which the RA's negotiate the FOH/BOH boundary within the ambiguous space of the hotel guest room the question that now must be addressed is: how does this boundary work contribute to hospitality impression management within the hotel? I argue that the results of this study provide strong evidence as to the vital importance of boundary work in the reliable (re)production of quality service encounters. In short, the construction of and movement across the FOH/BOH boundary is vital for the performance of the hospitality impression so central to the quality service encounter.

Due to the central role that guest contact has in the work engaged by hotel receptionists and restaurant staff, research on the service encounter conventionally focuses on these front-line staff (Hartline et al. 2003; Kang et al. 2004; Lee & Hu 2004; Luchars & Hinkin 1996). For these employees the boundary between FOH hospitality performance space and BOH non-performance space is clear. Invariably it takes the form of very physical barriers – the front office desk and the kitchen door for example (Goffman 1959). Due to the concrete nature of these markers, it is easy to overlook the important role they play in the management of the hospitality impression within a hotel. In other words, where the context is self-evident and taken for granted it loses significance. As a result, attention tends to be focused on the actors – the front-line staff – and their individual

traits (Forseth 2005; Iacobucci & Ostrom 1993; Karatepe & Sokmen 2006; Karatepe et al. 2006; Moshavi 2004; Ryoo 2005; Vieira 2005).

It is by examining the work of the housekeeping staff – in particular the RAs – that the context of the service encounter becomes fore-grounded. While largely invisible to both guests and service industry researchers (for exceptions see Allen & Pryke 1994; Rawstron 1999), RAs daily navigate considerable complexity and ambiguity as they attend to their service work. The complexity comes from the uncertain and intermittent presence of the guest in their otherwise cleaning dominated work role. The ambiguity comes from the absence of concrete and certain boundary markers that signal when the service impression performance must be switched on. In other words, within the terrain of the RA's work the usual strategy of managing space through physical barriers in order to minimise the possibility of a 'dropped veil' revealing the inauthentic commercially driven nature of the service performance is not possible. Instead, the service encounter – the moment of truth (Mahesh 1993) for the hotel – is reliant on the RA cuing into more amorphous social and temporal cues. For this reason, the service impression of any hotel is at its most vulnerable within the ambiguous space of the guest room and accommodation corridor. The (re)production of quality service encounters in the hotel housekeeping area therefore, is reliant on the RAs being able to identify and move across the FOH/BOH boundary using the available social and temporal cues. As the results suggest, in the ambiguous space of the guest room the RAs identify and manage the boundary between FOH and BOH through objects associated with the guest and aspects of their own self by using temporal cues and the physical presence/absence of the guest.

While surfaces within the guest room are at the centre of the RA's work tasks the status of this object-space as FOH or BOH is dependant on the presence or absence of the guest. When a room has been vacated the status of the room is

clearly BOH. In this context, the RA must attend to the residue left behind from the previous guest's BOH performance. As the cleaning activities take place out of sight of the hotel guest – and largely the hotel management – the actions and presentation of the RA's self can also slip over the work/non-work boundary. In other words, the BOH status of the guest room in this context creates the possibility of social chat, TV watching and even other more intimate social practices for the RAs. As the self-checking practice suggests however, this BOH categorisation of the room has a clear temporal boundary. Once the allotted time is up, the condition of the guest room must conform to guest expectations of what a clean and available FOH hotel space should look like (Lockyer 2005). Due to the general invisibility of the housekeeping operation, this movement of the guest room across the BOH/FOH boundary by the RA is only visible when it is not performed adequately. As Allen and Pryke (1994: 468) note of cleaners in the financial buildings of London, 'their existence as a workforce...only becomes apparent through their non-work; that is, by what they have not cleaned'. In the same way, the cleaning performance of the RA and the clean status of the room is only visible when it enters a service encounter involving a guest complaint about the inadequate cleanliness of the room.

When the cleaning is of a stay-over room, the BOH/FOH status is much more ambiguous. For a start there is the possible presence of the guest. In the presence of the guest, the room and the cleaning activities transform into a FOH service impression management. This demands that the RA talk and act in a way that gives an impression of genuine warmth and hospitality. Like any other service encounter within the hotel, the impression of a personalised hospitality demands that the activities associated with the 'generalized business function' of the hotel (Wood 1994) must be disguised. Thus, the RA's concerns about the extra time this social interaction will incur for the cleaning schedule and the need to clean other rooms must be concealed behind the service performance curtain.

Unlike service encounters in the hotel reception or restaurant areas, service encounters that take place within the guest room carry an additional uncertainty. Due to the isolation and lack of public visibility of activities that occur in the guest rooms, there lurks the possibility of uncivil behaviour in each service encounter between RAs and hotel guests. Again this links back to the ambiguous and shifting nature of the BOH/FOH status of the guest room. While the presence of the guest necessitates that the RA move across the BOH/FOH performance boundary, the same applies for the hotel guest. While some RAs fail to achieve this movement at the right time – as the opening quote to the introduction illustrates – some guests also fail to make that shift. While RA Betty witnessed a private argument for example, Housekeeping Manager Fran was also very aware of this possibility resulting in personal safety concerns for the RAs.

Other important boundary markers within the context of the stay-over room are objects belonging to or being used by the guests. While not physically present, the clothes and water glasses being used by the guest give a presence to the idea of the guest and in this way invoke the service impression performance. On one hand this service impression is gained through the impression of privacy. For hotel guests to 'feel at home' they must be given genuine sense privacy and this is only really possible in the guest's room (Bunzel et al. 2002; Wood 1994). In addition, the guest's belongings operate as a proxy for the guest him/her self and must be treated with due care in the absence of the owner. Thus, the protection of the contact lens – inadvertently thrown away with the water – becomes as important as the smile in the guest's assessment of service quality.

The results of this paper suggest two key implications for research of hospitality service work. The first involves the importance of context. More specifically, is acknowledgment of the complexity and ambiguity of that crucial service industries boundary between FOH/BOH. Theorising the service encounter as boundary work provides a valuable lens for understanding the

challenges many service industry workers face in managing their day-to-day service performance. This is particularly so for service employees who operate within ambiguous spaces. Through this framework the service encounter – or more specifically service impression management – is primarily about the management of boundaries. A second implication and direction for future research is the non front-line service staff. As the concept of 'the moment of truth' (Mahesh 1993) suggests, all service encounters are pivotal to the overall impression of quality service for any hotel. The results of this study emphasise the vulnerability of the service encounter in the ambiguous BOH regions within the hotel operation. Namasivam and Hinkin's (2003: 26) suggest that 'by gaining an understanding of factors that affect the success of the service encounter, managers will be able to prepare their front-line staff effectively to satisfy the customer's requirements'. The results of this paper suggest that this understanding and preparation should also include the non-front-line staff – such as the housekeeping staff.

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